# THE BURGESS PERSIAN LETTERS[1]

*Edited by* BENJAMIN SCHWARTZ

## *APPENDIX*

### INTERVIEW WITH ANNA [Mrs. Edward] BURGESS[2]

MY ancestors, on the sides of both parents, were Armenians, and I think for some time have lived in Tabriz. My father, Daoud Khan Seguinoff, was always in the military service of the Shah of Persia. My dear mother died some time before him. My uncles were men in high position. We were six in family, two brothers and four sisters. Both of my brothers were merchants in Tabreez; both are now dead. I am the eldest of the sisters. My next sister is the widow of Aga Pedros, an Armenian merchant. She lives in Tehràn, and has three sons. My youngest sister, Tamar, is the widow of Dr. Cormick. Dr. Cormick's father came to Persia to be on the medical staff of the Shah. He married an Armenian lady, and Dr. C. was born in Tabriz . . .

We had known Charles and Edward Burgess a long time. They were merchants of china, guns, and many other things, and went to and fro between Tabriz and Tehràn. Edward Burgess asked for me of my father. I loved him even before we were married. Then we were married at my father's house . . .

When my husband was appointed to superintend the printing of the Government newspaper in Tehràn, we got a few things needful for our house, and then our little son John was born. Mr. Ronald Thompson was his Godfather (as he was afterwards for our daughter Fanny). Both of our children were baptized in our house in Tehràn, according to the Armenian rites. And the priests said they registered the times, but I am not very sure about them, for those gentlemen neglect to do it at the very same time, and it is said they often make mistakes.

[1] In addition to the Burgess letters, Mrs. Thomas F. Burgess' gift included a printed . . . *Notice respecting the Trade of the Northern Provinces of Persia, addressed to T. H. Villiers, Esq. by C. H. Burgess,* probably written in 1832, and manuscript copies, in Charles Burgess' hand, of his memoranda on the state of trade and political conditions in Persia written, in 1833, to the Duke of Richmond and, in 1835, to Lord Ponsonby. Neither of the latter has been printed, so far as the Library can discover, but there seems hardly enough more information in them, or in the Villiers *Notice,* than is given in the *Letters,* to warrant publication here. T. H. Villiers, to whom the *Notice* was addressed, was a Member of Parliament, and had been in the colonial office. The *Notice,* though printed in the customary form, was not included among the Parliamentary Papers. Mr. Villiers' death in 1832, presumably the date of the *Notice,* may account for the omission, since it may have been printed too late for him to present it to Parliament.

The printed *Notice,* and the manuscripts and transcripts of the other memoranda, together with the original letters are, of course, available in the Library.

[2] The manuscript of this interview, of which a portion is printed here, is dated "C. Belmont Villas. Leicester. March, 1880."



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My husband applied himself with knowledge to the Government business. But he was always sad about his brother, and for his dear father and mother so far away. Every time he had the fever, more pain settled in his back and limbs. Our baby was then delicate in the stomach, and was always sick. He died at eighteen months old. My Edward mourned him as if he had been older, for he had hoped to send him to England, to give him to his dear father to put to school. We buried his body in the Armenian graveyard in Tehràn. When our Fanny was born, we saw that she too was something like her father, but not quite so much as our boy was. Edward grew weaker, and more often ill, and I worked, worked, for him and for my baby. I would not let him do anything I could do for him.

Then it was said "if he was to live at all, he must be taken to England." We let our house and sold all we could for money for the journey & to provide that Charles' children should not die of want of food, for he loved them for Charles' sake. The Government gave him six months leave of absence, and the money for all that time. But oh! our hearts did tremble and sink, for he grew thin as a skeleton. Mr. Ronald Thompson and the doctor got for him a takhteravan — a what you say, a litter slung between two mules, to travel in. And sometimes I rode and more often I walked by his side. The servant had our Fanny on another mule. It was a very dreadful journey. We travelled as fast as we could, for he longed to see his own country. Often we were obliged to stay at those very dreadful Mahommedan villages, lest he should die with the hard travel: for the disease had settled in his spine and limbs, and often movement gave him such agony that he looked as dead. I never left him, he was in my eyes night and day. I cooked for him and washed by the road-side. My life was in his life: I saw not our baby, I saw not anything but my husband. Our money, and our provisions for the road were using up — Oh! we were nearly three months on that journey from Tehràn to Tabriz! When we were eight days from Tabriz, there came to meet us my father, my two uncles, and my kind brother, Dr. Cormick. Then I trusted that they would guide us safe. We both had had the horrible knowledge, that, if he had had to be buried outside one of those villages, the dogs would have eaten him directly. But we reached Tabriz after eight days, and laid him in his own house, and Dr. Cormick attended to him. He lived for six weeks longer. When he was able, he spoke to me much to take our Fanny to his father directly I could, "and be sure she is put to learn the English so soon as she can speak." We talked with much love and much weeping. About a week before he died, he wrote a letter, a long letter, to his father. Then when Mr. Abbott came to see him, he said to him, "You will find in that large book a letter I have written; when I am dead, take it out, & send it straightway to my father." I very often wonder what has become of that letter, for I should like my Fanny

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to have it, Oh! so much! When Fanny was three days past one year old, he died. We had been married just five years.

He was buried in the little lovely green Armenian cemetery just outside the walls of Tabriz, close by the side of my uncle. We placed a small stone with English letters, on the grave . . .

Many years later, in Tabriz, we stayed some weeks with my dear nephew, for my Fanny wished to put a larger and better stone on her father's grave. My nephew assisted her; he chose for us a piece — a slice — of fine grained marble from the mountains, it cost about three tomans, and the shaping and the letters cost about five tomans. The inscription is now double, both in English and in Armenian. My dear father's grave is four or five English yards from it; it is among the graves of all my relations. And old Mr. & Mrs. Cormick and the Europeans are all buried there. The trees are very beautiful.

THE END

# NEWS OF THE MONTH

## GIFTS

DURING the month ending April 15, 1942, there were received as gifts for the Reference Department, 3,411 volumes, 24,863 pamphlets, 52 maps, and 282 prints. The Circulation Department received as gifts 492 volumes and 1,054 pamphlets.

The following list of donors [of New York City, unless otherwise indicated] with a brief description of their gifts, represents a selection from a much longer list. [*See* "Principal Donors in April," elsewhere in this issue of the *Bulletin*.]

### *Collection*

Chemnyco, Inc. — a collection of more than ten thousand books, pamphlets, periodicals and other material from the files of Chemnyco, Inc.

### *Presentation Copies from Authors*

Mr. John Henry Bartlett, Washington, D. C. — an autographed copy of his *The Story of Sunapee,* Washington, 1941.

Dr. Philip Birnbaum, Philadelphia — *The Arabic Commentary of Yefet Ben 'Ali the Karaite on the Book of Hosea,* Philadelphia, 1942.

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